Who Does What: The People and Words You'll Meet While Planning Mom's Care

Nineteen roles and terms in plain language, and what to write down about each.

Elder law attorney, applications specialist, private pay, open issue. Everyone seems to assume you already know who does what. These are the people and words you're most likely to meet at the planning stage, each in plain language, with what to write down when it comes up.

The definitions are for following the conversation. They aren't for working out where Mom stands yourself.

People

Medicaid planner

In this roadmap, your Medicaid planner works in education, organization, planning support and coordination: bringing the care, financial and Medicaid findings together and helping the family put its next steps in order.

WRITE DOWN The questions you want to bring to the planning conversation.

Elder law attorney

An attorney who deals daily with the issues surrounding old age. The work can include preparing power of attorney documents and exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid. In this roadmap, legal advice and legal documents belong here. [1]

WRITE DOWN Any decision that involves a legal document, so it can go to the attorney.

Licensed financial or insurance professional

In this roadmap, the person insurance and investment products belong to. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau notes that many professionals must be licensed or registered by a government agency, and suggests checking qualifications. [2]

WRITE DOWN The name, what they are licensed to do, and what they have told you.

Tax professional

In this roadmap, brought in when a plan needs one. The Administration for Community Living says families with large estates should consult an expert for advice about income, estate and inheritance tax planning. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN Who prepares Mom's tax returns, and where the recent ones are kept.

Applications specialist

In this roadmap, the person the Medicaid application is prepared with.

WRITE DOWN Your questions about the application and its timing.

State Medicaid agency

The office that takes Medicaid applications and decides eligibility. Each state operates its own program day to day, so a family applies through a local office in its state. [5]

WRITE DOWN Any letter from it: the date, and what it asks for.

Facility social worker

A member of staff at the hospital or facility. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that social workers and discharge planners in hospitals and nursing homes can help facilitate a family meeting or refer you to someone who can. [6]

WRITE DOWN The name, the direct phone number, and what you've been told.

Geriatric care manager

A care professional, usually a licensed nurse, social worker or therapist trained in caring for older adults. The work can include creating care plans and making referrals to financial, legal or medical professionals. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether one is involved, and what they have recommended.

Paying for care

Long-term care

Medical and non-medical care for people who have a chronic illness or disability. Most of it is help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, such as dressing, bathing and using the bathroom. [8]

WRITE DOWN The help Mom gets each day, and where.

Private pay

Paying for care out of your own pocket. Medicare.gov says most people who enter nursing homes start this way. [9]

WRITE DOWN What is paid each month, from which account, and by whom.

Medicare

Medicare.gov says Medicare and most health insurance, including Medigap, don't pay for long-term care services. It adds that a person still needs Medicare for hospital care, doctor's services, drugs and medical supplies while in a nursing home. [8] [9]

WRITE DOWN Which of Mom's bills Medicare is paying, as far as you know.

Medicaid

A joint federal and state program that helps pay health care costs for people with limited income and, in some cases, resources, who meet other requirements. Unlike Medicare, it does pay for custodial care in nursing homes and at home. Eligibility rules vary from state to state, and the program may have another name in yours. [9] [10] [2]

WRITE DOWN What you've been told about it so far, and who said it.

Eligibility determination

The state's decision on whether a person is eligible for Medicaid. The state then makes a separate determination of whether the person qualifies for long-term care services. Neither is something a family works out on its own. [10]

WRITE DOWN The date and wording of any letter from the agency. Leave the conclusion to the agency and the professionals.

Papers and the plan

Power of attorney

A legal document that gives someone else legal authority to make decisions about a person's money or property. [11]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has one, the date on it, who is named, and where the original is.

Documentation

The papers an application rests on. The Administration for Community Living says an applicant provides documentation to verify general and financial requirements. [5]

WRITE DOWN Which papers you have, and which you are still looking for.

Barrier or open issue

The roadmap's words for something that stands between Mom's situation today and Medicaid eligibility, or a question nobody has answered yet. The plan sorts them into care, income, assets, transfers, documents and legal matters.

WRITE DOWN What the issue is, who raised it, and whether you know it or were told it.

Medicaid Action Plan

The written plan this step produces: the actions in order, who is responsible for each, the dates and the professional reviews. It is built with your Medicaid planner, and it isn't an eligibility decision.

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet. Your page of summaries and questions is what it starts from.

Professional review

The roadmap's term for the point where a decision goes to the professional it belongs to, such as an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional, before the written plan is settled.

WRITE DOWN Which decisions are waiting, and for whom.

Target application date

The date the plan aims at for applying, set with professional guidance. The Administration for Community Living says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances. [5]

WRITE DOWN The question “when should we apply?” and who you will ask.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words and roles. It doesn't say which of them apply to Mom, state any limit or figure, or tell you whether she qualifies for anything, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Lines marked with a number come from the sources below. The roadmap's own roles and terms are described the way the Medicaid Planning Roadmap uses them.

Ready for the next step?

You can follow the conversation now, and you know whose question is whose. The planning interview uses the same plain language: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else’s money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Legal Steps for Financial Well-being
4. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. AARP, Geriatric Care Managers Advocate for Older Adults — and Their Caregivers
8. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long-term care
9. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
10. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
11. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options